FORMATION OF LOCAL-HISTORY MATERIALS AND LOCAL PUBLICATIONS COLLECTIONS AS A TECHNOLOGICAL CYCLE

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Relevance of the topic

The relevance of this topic arises from the clear need of young readers in modern children's libraries to obtain new local-history knowledge from reliable sources of different kinds. All young readers should have equal opportunities to use the diverse resources of a library's local-history collection, whether in print or among local publications [9].

The problem of developing a children's library's local-history collection and collection of local publications has been aggravated by the prolonged period of self-isolation associated with the COVID-19 pandemic, which has substantially changed the modern world. For children unable to learn about their region through excursions and field trips, these collections can serve as a compensatory resource. They can move local-history research into a virtual and reading-based environment and partly replace experiences in the real world.

The author argues that citizens' proper understanding of how to use a children's library's local-history collection and local publications can help overcome this unexpected humanitarian crisis. Studying the features of these collections may help develop appropriate responses to a situation in which people risk forgetting their history and losing historical memory. Virtual visits to memorials and museums can partly compensate for reduced opportunities to learn about regional history in person.

N. V. Lopatina notes that library local-history work has for decades been one of the most important activities of public libraries. Its development is connected with wider changes in Russian society, including social, economic, cultural, educational and information-related changes [6].

Research problem, aim and methods

The topic has attracted attention from numerous scientific organizations and institutions. Nevertheless, rapid social change and extraordinary circumstances continually create a need for new solutions where traditional approaches are no longer adequate.

The central problem is the continuing need to examine the development and preservation of children's libraries' local-history collections and local publications. The aim of the study is to examine the problems involved in creating and preserving these collections.

The research draws on works by O. V. Boronikhina, V. V. Brezhneva, N. I. Gendina, V. N. Ilyin, V. K. Klyuev, N. I. Kolkova, O. Yu. Latyshev, L. N. Makarova, N. V. Lopatina, I. S. Pilko, V. N. Podkopa■■■, L. P. Chaikina and others. The methods include analysis of scholarly literature, synthesis, comparison, collation, generalization and bibliographic analysis.

Results: categories of local-history resources

According to V. V. Brezhneva, the historical experience of individual regions and the influence of local-history knowledge on regional life—especially education, upbringing, the development of younger generations and specialist training—have brought this knowledge into the centre of many public and governmental processes [1].

The resources commonly used in children's libraries' local-history and local-publication collections include books, hypertext, photographs, audio files, films and videos, animations, 3D constructors and online local-history quizzes. The range of materials used by children and teachers to study regional history is wider, although some types are

less commonly used in Russia [2]. The collection's typology and formats matter because it may contain many different kinds of materials.

One group consists of materials documenting traditional crafts practised in a locality. Related materials describe local cultural traditions, holidays, ceremonies, traditional clothing and distinctive household objects. Such books are often published for anniversaries of groups promoting these crafts and traditions, with publication costs included in a municipal budget [3]. They can then be added to a children's library's local-history collection.

Another group comprises local-history materials published on social-networking sites. These may describe architecture, prevailing styles, exterior and interior design, and distinctive colour schemes. Such material is often freely accessible online and can be read, printed and downloaded without payment, making it widely available through a children's library's internet access point.

Music characteristic of a region, republic or district should also be included, particularly where it has been documented through ethnographic expeditions. As with book presentations held at children's libraries, presentations of CDs, CD-ROMs and DVDs by well-known local performers and groups may result in copies being donated to the library. Dialect features characteristic of a locality and reflected in written records should form a separate group of local-history resources [7].

Dialectological research is not always supported by local communities, so libraries should not rely exclusively on donations from authors and publishers. If academic publishers and researchers become aware of genuine interest among library staff and young readers, arrangements may be made to supply relevant books. Some resources belong to several groups at once—for example, unique local folk songs with distinctive dialect features [4]. Similarly, architectural decoration in a settlement may share themes and visual features with local decorative and applied arts.

Media and presentation

Another characteristic of a children's library's local-history collection and local publications is the medium through which information is transmitted, since the medium can determine the material's form. For example, the duration of a recording on a small or long-playing record can establish the natural boundaries of an album of music created by local residents. Likewise, the proportions of a tablecloth embroidered with a unique local pattern determine its shape, the method used to apply the design, its colours and other features.

Grant applications may be submitted to finance local-history activities and allow libraries to purchase materials that attract curious young readers. The same principle applies to printed works produced locally using distinctive paper, ink or watermarks. Once scanned and placed on a children's library website, these works continue to reflect the traditions of their place of origin [5]. In essence, artefacts created before widespread standardization bear traces of local traditions, and these may remain visible when the artefacts are presented electronically.

When building these collections, library staff should consider that young visitors may wish to supplement what they read in books with materials on the library's website. A collection's character is shaped not only by the original properties of its materials but also by the purpose of the library's webpages and the audiences they serve.

Some social networks seek to attract large audiences in order to expand the market for advertising. Local-history material placed on such platforms may consequently be aimed at a less demanding audience [6], with illustration and entertainment taking precedence. Serious students and children's-library users are unlikely to seek detailed local-history information on platforms crowded with advertising and material of questionable quality. Examples mentioned in the article include Moi Mir, Odnoklassniki, VKontakte and Twitter.

By contrast, webpages specifically designed for curious children can present detailed local-history material without placing it alongside low-quality, purely advertising content. Participation in such pages may require users to demonstrate a particular social status or membership in a young local-history group or club [7].

Resource constraints and possible solutions

Providing the resources needed to develop local-history collections and local publications remains a serious, though potentially solvable, challenge for libraries. The key difficulty is a lack of material resources. The small number of publications available for local-history education has several objective and subjective causes.

First, contemporary authors rarely work on commission for publishers willing to support high-quality local-history works for younger readers. Until relatively recently, authors could seek grants from charitable foundations and non-profit organizations at international or national level. The current socioeconomic situation, however, does not sufficiently encourage authors who write accessibly for children and young people about the history of their home region.

Second, authors tend to choose genres considered commercially successful and capable of attracting a broad audience and generating substantial royalties. Even if children's local-history literature were again able to receive grants at former levels, relatively few authors might be willing to enter grant competitions to write it. Third, a book intended for children may be too short to make a project attractive to an author who would need to conduct extensive research but present the results in a limited space.

For these reasons, funding and resource provision for local-history collections is difficult and requires library staff to adopt flexible and sometimes unconventional solutions. When local-history literature does not contain information requested by young readers, libraries can use the internet. Alongside specialist local-history websites, many other online resources may illuminate aspects of a locality's past that have not been adequately covered elsewhere.

A curious reader can search for information through specialist websites and search engines such as Yandex, Rambler, Google, Yahoo and Bing. The resulting collection of current local-history resources may support presentations at international and national youth conferences, symposia and congresses. It may also provide material for scholarly reviews on local history for children and young people, as well as research theses submitted for discussion within the academic community.

N. V. Lopatina emphasizes that preserving cultural heritage is one of the principal functions of library local-history work, and that libraries' responsibilities for preserving regional cultural heritage are reflected in regulatory documents and Russian state programmes [6]. Resource provision can also be strengthened by publicizing grants for local-history research.

In the author's view, one productive way to support a children's library's local-history collection and local publications is to participate in an interlibrary electronic catalogue that includes local-history literature. A children's book may have been presented and donated to another library, perhaps with a dedication by its author. If it is not in high demand among the receiving library's young readers, interlibrary exchange can allow readers elsewhere to consult it.

Another approach is to encourage local authors to contribute to annual publications and commemorative volumes about community members' activities and achievements. Library staff, with support from young readers, can contact community leaders, non-profit organizations and associations. Congratulating community members on new titles, awards, anniversaries and other occasions may draw attention to the library's needs and encourage donations to its local-history collections.

Publications produced by processing and reinterpreting these resources generally aim to popularize local-history knowledge and make it available through popular-science media. The principal audiences for local-history websites include supplementary-education teachers who run local-history clubs, schoolteachers, university lecturers, doctoral and postdoctoral researchers, doctoral candidates, postgraduate students and university-age young people [7]. Most materials produced on the basis of a children's library's collections are also accessible to a broad readership.

Conclusions

A local-history publication based on identifying and developing a substantial collection of local-history materials and local publications can describe community life and important commemorative dates. Genres may include articles, reviews, digests, notices, greetings and congratulatory addresses [8].

The study concludes that creating local-history and local-publication collections as a technological cycle should follow several principles. Both local-history materials and local publications should be brought together, because they form a valuable part of a library's holdings and may contain items not duplicated in other libraries in the Russian Federation. Texts, audio files, video files and materials in other formats have their own value and can complement other local-history resources in the overall collection.

The content of a children's library's local-history collection and local publications is most fully reflected in the library's internal documentation, which also helps make these collections distinctive. The medium in which an item

is preserved substantially determines its content-related possibilities. The characteristics of the medium become key features of the item and may be regarded by readers as inseparable from it.

Resource provision supports the foundation of a library's local-history work. Collections in a region's central children's library should be developed with the greatest practical completeness, in anticipation of active use by young readers. Preserving local-history documents and local publications is a matter of considerable responsibility for the staff of each region's central children's library and for those who promote knowledge of the region.

Core resources include published documents devoted wholly to the region served by the library. Publications about a part of the region may also qualify if they contain substantial and fundamental information about it. The value of materials does not depend on their physical format: printed and electronic publications can be included on equal terms. Audiovisual materials, microfilms and microfiche may also be incorporated, irrespective of format, type, language, time or place of publication.

An analysis of bibliographic references in local-history articles suggests that collections are most actively identified and expanded through international scientific, scientific-practical and scientific-methodological conferences, symposia and congresses on local history and regional studies. Timely and substantial resourcing of a children's library's local-history and local-publication collections, the article concludes, helps scientific publications appear more frequently and facilitates research trips for further local-history investigations.

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